

The ghost of Butterfield and the writing of UK official nuclear history

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ABSTRACT

In a major critical article about UK official history written in 1949, Herbert Butterfield, highlighted what he viewed as the inherent weaknesses of government-sponsored history and argued that all such histories should be subjected to 'unremitting scrutiny'. Despite the resurgence of interest in analysing the wide range of UK official histories in recent years one important subject has been neglected: UK policy on nuclear weapons. This article seeks to remedy this gap in the historiography of UK official history by focusing attention on the work of the three main official nuclear historians. A number of key questions are considered: are the official nuclear histories simply attempts by governments to 'control the past'?; are they 'honest' histories, reflecting the highest professional standards?; did the historians have unimpeded access to all the documents?; were the historians 'institutionalized'?; and are there significant gaps in their coverage of important areas of nuclear policy? The article argues that while they provide significant and important contributions to knowledge, not available to those without privileged access, these histories do require cautious, constant scrutiny and challenge. Even with such scrutiny, however, it is argued that they should be regarded as 'foundational' studies.

KEYWORDS:

- Official nuclear history; 'unremitting scrutiny'; 'secrecy'; 'honest' history; 'Faustian Bargain'; 'foundational' studies

The historiography of British nuclear history has been directly or indirectly influenced by the work of the three main official nuclear historians, Margaret Gowing, Lorna Arnold and Matthew Jones. [Footnote 1](#) Gowing's first study, *Britain and Atomic Energy 1939–1945* was published in 1964 and was followed by a two volume study *Independence and Deterrence: Britain and Atomic Energy 1945–1952* (written with the assistance of Lorna Arnold), published in 1974 (L. Arnold ; M. Gowing). Lorna Arnold went on to write three official nuclear histories, *A Very Special Nuclear Relationship: British Atomic Weapons Tests in Australia*, published in 1987; *Windscale 1957: Anatomy of a*

Nuclear Accident published in 1995; and *Britain and the H-Bomb*, with the assistance of Katherine Pyne, published in 2001.[Footnote2](#) After quite a long gap, Matthew Jones was appointed by the Cabinet Office in 2008 and at the time of writing has published two studies, *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume 1 - from the V-Bomber era to the arrival of Polaris, 1945–1964*, and *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume II – the Labour Government and the Polaris Programme, 1964–1970*, both published in 2017.[Footnote3](#)

Despite these important studies, the writing of official nuclear history in Britain has surprisingly not been the subject of the kind of external academic scrutiny (and controversy) which has affected the multitude of other military, intelligence, and civil official histories that have been written since the publication of the diplomatic documents on the origins of the First World War by the Foreign Office in 1920.[Footnote4](#) This article sets out to remedy this lacunae by first examining the on-going debate about official history in general and then focusing on the UK official nuclear histories, assessing the relevance of the kinds of criticisms made by Herbert Butterfield, a figure of major intellectual importance in British historical circles, and other critics like Sir Basil Liddell Hart and Desmond Williams.[Footnote5](#) The focus, in particular, is on Butterfield's critique, linking official history and state power, and the way government's attempt to control the nuclear past. In the light of his scepticism, the central questions posed in this article are whether, UK official nuclear history can be regarded as 'honest history' and whether his plea for 'unremitting scrutiny' is an essential requirement for academic nuclear historians. By examining the evolution of official nuclear history writing from the Second World War to the present day, the study argues that the changing political, institutional, and historiographical contexts in which these histories were written significantly shaped their content and interpretation. Reassessing the work of Gowing, Arnold and Jones provides an opportunity to evaluate the contribution of their official nuclear histories to the broader tradition of UK official history, while situating them within wider debates on nuclear weapons, secrecy, public interest, and the writing of contemporary history. A concluding section considers the question of whether there can be common ground between official and non-official nuclear historians.

Secret drawers', self-censorship and 'unremitting scrutiny'

In 2021 Patrick Salmon, the Chief Historian at the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office, published a study of the ongoing debate about the criticisms of official history initiated by Herbert Butterfield in 1949 in his article 'Official History: its Pitfalls and its Criteria' published in *Studies: An Irish Quarterly Review*.[Footnote6](#) Based on his interest in pre-First World War and pre-Second World War government diplomatic documents Butterfield launched

a scathing attack on government-sponsored history after 1945 in which he argued that governments invariably attempted to control and manipulate the writing of official history to serve their own interests.[Footnote7](#) In his view there was no government in Europe that 'wanted the public to know all the truth'.[Footnote8](#) In a letter to A.J.P.Taylor in August 1949, who was also a sceptic of official history, he expressed the view that as a historian he was 'against all governments' because he believed that 'something oblique' was going on behind the scenes, 'giving them a seamy side'.[Footnote9](#) There was always the danger of governments, he believed, interfering in the selection of documents and official historians being 'lulled to sleep by the soft charms of officialdom'.[Footnote10](#)

Butterfield's view that 'something oblique' was going on behind the scenes of government and that they did not wish the public to know all the truth, led to his conviction that information would always be held back from the official historian if it reflected badly on the government or if officials perceived it to be against the national interest. This reflected his unshakable belief that governments maintained metaphorical 'secret drawers' containing documents that would never be revealed even to official historians.[Footnote11](#) Governments, he maintained, would try 'to press upon historians the keys to all of the drawers, but one', because they are very anxious 'to spread the belief that this single one contains no secret of importance'. In fact, this 'secret drawer' was the one that historians needed to see if they were to get their hands 'on something of significance'.[Footnote12](#) Despite the fact that a number of official historians, like W.N.Medlicott and E.L.Woodward, denied that there were such 'secret drawers' and that they had been given 'the full run of the archives', Butterfield never wavered from this conviction. In his view official historians could never discount their existence because they were not fully in control of the archives. Officials could retain control of any information they did not wish them to see, if they so wished. As a result, he argued that official history was always likely 'to fall short of academic history' because it was 'impossible to check all its sources'.[Footnote13](#)

Apart from the problem of 'secret drawers', Butterfield was also concerned about the possibility of self-censorship exercised by official historians. Such historians were directly or indirectly the servants of government, and with their special access to the archives they enjoyed privileges not available to academic historians. In such circumstances, he believed that it would be only natural for them to be concerned that these special privileges would be taken away if they revealed information that was highly critical of government policies. Another critic of official history, Desmond Williams, a close associate of Butterfield, (and someone who had experience in the official history field) argued that official historians were likely to be people in whom the Cabinet Office and Foreign Office had a 'special confidence'.[Footnote14](#) Because they had to sign the Official Secrets Act, they were prevented from revealing what government

officials regarded as secret material which would harm state interests. In both cases there was pressure on the official historian to engage in self-censorship. As such, Butterfield argued that 'official history could not be judged by the methods adopted in all other kinds of history, that seek 'direct reference to the totality of the sources'.[Footnote15](#)

This was a view supported by the military historian Sir Basil Liddell Hart who claimed that official history was 'official but not history'.[Footnote16](#) As a result of his concern about official assessments of the First World War Liddell Hart argued that official history tended to serve the interests of the government of the day. It was largely propaganda. Official historians, in his view, were not able to follow where the evidence led, something that was of critical importance to academic historians. They might have 'to overlook, or even suppress' significant information in the interests of their employers, the government. This meant that they could not meet 'the tests of objectivity, balance and independent judgment' and that, at best, they could only produce 'a bland, diluted version of the truth'. This meant, that in Liddell Hart's view, 'official history cannot be honest'.[Footnote17](#)

Butterfield had a slightly different view. In correspondence with official historians of his day, he absolved them of being dishonest. However, he argued that others in the future might not be so honest. In any age there might, he believed, be 'scoundrels' who did not meet the exacting standards of the best academic historians 'and it would be impossible for anybody to answer them'.[Footnote18](#) The 'scoundrels' would always have the upper hand in debates with non-official historians. He believed in 'history for its own sake', not as something that was perceived to be useful for society in some imagined way. Academic, non-official history, had absolute primacy in his thinking. If there was to be official history, it had to be submitted to unremitting and relentless scrutiny (Bentley [Citation2012a](#); T. McIntire [Citation2004](#)).

Butterfield's writings have undoubtedly had a significant, if contested, impact on the study of history. In his 1931 book *The Whig Interpretation of History* Butterfield sets out what he regards as the crucial importance of high professional standards for historians (Butterfield [Citation1931a](#)). History, he argued should be studied strictly for its own sake and not to validate modern political causes or objectives. According to this view official history, which often has as one of its purposes to learn lessons from the past, leads to distorted historical truth. He advocated what he called 'technical history' which involved a highly disciplined, granular, value-free inquiry, which dealt with the complexities and unforeseen circumstances of the past. History should be written by independent people free to reach their own judgments after full access to the documentary record.

Despite the importance of his philosophy of history, his work has nevertheless been subject to criticism. The influential historian, G.R.Elton, argues that he was

right to argue that history had to be studied for its own sake, but his emphasis on value-free history was somewhat undermined by his strong Christian convictions. He also accuses Butterfield of failing to recognize that there is a wider variety of historical source material than he identifies. In Elton's words: 'he never progressed to a full understanding of the nature, range and problems of historical evidence'. (Elton [Citation1984](#))[Footnote19](#) Supporters of official history, like Patrick Salmon and Philip Scarpino, have also argued that he fails to understand the value of official history for non-official historians and the wider public, as well as the common ground between official and academic historians (Scarpino [Citation1994](#)).

Setting the model of UK official nuclear history

It is perhaps surprising that, given this important debate in British historiography and the vital importance of the subject, there has been very limited 'unremitting scrutiny' by academic historians of the UK official nuclear histories. Margaret Gowing, the first of Britain's official nuclear historians was one of those scholars in whom, the Cabinet Office had particular confidence. She had worked closely with Keith Hancock on the Official History of *British War Economy* (Hancock and Gowing [Citation1949](#)). Hancock was a key figure in government-sponsored official history studies becoming Supervisor and later Editor of the UK Civil Series of the History of the Second World War. His influence over, and support for, Gowing was to be long-lasting.

Draft copies of the Hancock/Gowing book were circulated to relevant departments in Whitehall in 1947 and the work 'evoked an instant torrent of official criticism and complaint'. Significantly, it appears that they were 'worn down' by the criticisms and accepted that changes should be made to the book.[Footnote20](#) Nevertheless, Hancock maintained a strong and lasting conviction that official history should be critical, revealing the messy and contested nature of decision-making and not simply focusing on the success stories. He understood that officials did not want to see policy portrayed as being the result of internecine warfare or muddle, improvisation and fortuitous decisions. This was, however, the nature of policy-making and official historians, he felt had to reflect this. This conviction was to have a major effect on Gowing's approach to official nuclear history, and on her successors, in the years ahead.

Despite the fact that she was an economic historian with no knowledge of science Gowing was recruited in 1959 from the Cabinet Office Staff by the UK Atomic Energy Authority (UKAEA) to act as a Department Record Officer (DRO) with a remit to write the history of the British atomic energy programme in the Second World War. Sir Roger Makins, an historian by training and a high-ranking diplomat, was chairman of the UKAEA Board and he reinforced the view expressed by Hancock that the study must be 'a serious historical work

written for publication and aimed primarily at the intelligent layman'.[Footnote21](#) With his long experience in the atomic energy world he insisted that it must not be a 'white washing operation' and Gowing must be given 'a free hand' to access the documents held by the UKAEA and other relevant departments. To ensure that this was the case a small academic committee was appointed to see that high standards of integrity were maintained. Gowing was, however, like all official historians, to be bound by the Official Secrets Act and departments involved could 'challenge the facts', and ultimately the Cabinet Office could refuse publication.[Footnote22](#)

In the Preface to *Britain and Atomic Energy* (1964) Gowing argued that she had all 'the normal freedom of an academic historian over access to documents, selection of material and the right to make independent comment'. She says she was given 'the fullest possible access to Government documents and that the study was 'written to the strict criteria of the historical profession'. In this respect, she says that the government was 'liberal minded' in its overall approach to the history. (Gowing [Citation1964](#)) It is noteworthy, however, that before publication the UKAEA insisted that her footnotes should be removed, 'with a nod to security'. It was not until the early 1980s that they were made available to the Public Records Office, making it difficult, if not impossible, for academic nuclear historians to check her sources.[Footnote23](#)

Gowing accepted that in such a contract between the Government and the historian there were always 'possibilities of conflict'. Although, she argued that there was no conflict in practice, she did accept that she engaged in some self-censorship, where she omitted 'the sharp comment or amusing story'. She said that despite this she was always concerned 'to keep the narrative in perspective and its balance correct'. She also conceded that there were two cases where she omitted quotations from documents 'because it was clear that they could harm the public interest'. (Gowing [Citation1964](#))

Following research by a later official nuclear historian, Matthew Jones, we now know that there were tensions, over the way she covered the sensitive case of the wartime meeting between Prime Minister Churchill and the eminent scientist, Niels Bohr, on 16 May 1944. There was disagreement over the attempts by the Cabinet Office to delay publication of the book during late 1963 and much of 1964. When the first draft of *Britain and Atomic Energy* was submitted to the Cabinet Office for review in early summer 1963 the Cabinet Secretary, Sir Burke Trend, was concerned that the treatment of the meeting between Churchill and Niels Bohr might reflect badly on the reputation of the former Prime Minister. Bohr had made the case to the Prime Minister that it was important to try to prevent an atomic arms race after the war ended and this was best done by informing the Soviet Union of the work being done on the bomb. The meeting failed rather badly with Churchill rejecting Bohr's proposal and even suggesting to officials that Bohr was 'dangerous' because he might pass on secrets about the bomb to scientists in the Soviet Union with whom he

was in touch. He even suggested that Bohr might be 'confined or at any rate made to see that he is very near the edge of mortal crimes'. At a time when trust in politicians was being severely tested by the Profumo scandal, Trend seemed to have been concerned that the wartime PM's reputation could be damaged by the coverage of these events in Gowing's book.[Footnote24](#) He felt that Churchill might be seen to be responsible for the postwar nuclear arms race and to have made unwarranted accusations against a world famous scientist.[Footnote25](#) Gowing, forcefully and successfully insisted that this should remain in her book. Nevertheless, she was required to modify her text and clearly attempts had been made by the Cabinet Secretary to interfere with what was included in the official account.[Footnote26](#)

Independence and deterrence (I&D)

In her preface to *Britain and Atomic Energy* Gowing indicated that it was 'the first installment of an Official History of the United Kingdom atomic energy project', indicating that there would be more volumes to follow. (Gowing [Citation1964](#)) Following its publication in October 1964 the question of a sequel study was once again raised. The Cabinet Secretary, however, was not very supportive. Trend considered that it would raise questions about the 50 year rule on government archives and would set a precedent for other postwar official histories. The case against a new round of official nuclear histories was, however, undermined by Prime Minister Alec Douglas Home, announcing in July 1964 that Gowing's wartime book was the 'first volume' indicating once again that there would be a second volume. Trend found this remark rather 'tiresome'.[Footnote27](#)

The issue was taken up by Sir William Penney, the key figure in Britain's development of atomic weapons, who had replaced Sir Roger Makins as the chairman of the AEA. Penney argued that the Americans were producing their own publication on postwar nuclear developments and Britain's contribution to the history of atomic energy would go by the board if the story was not told (Hewlett and Duncan, [Citation1969](#)). Trend seemed to have been convinced by this argument and took the case to Prime Minister, Harold Wilson, who had been elected in October 1964. The Prime Minister agreed to the new study and in March 1965 Trend wrote to Penney indicating that Gowing could go ahead and that her second volume would be a pilot for a new round of peacetime official histories. This led in 1967 to an announcement by Wilson that the 50 year rule would be reduced to 30 years. The ground was set for Gowing to undertake her study of British nuclear policy between 1945 and 1952 (L. Arnold [Citation2000](#)).

Gowing apparently found the writing of what became the two volume *Independence and Deterrence (I&D)* 'a very gruelling intellectual job'. (MacLeod [Citation2016](#)) Apart from a difficult private life she was faced with a

huge volume of documents from a range of departments. To help deal with this Lorna Arnold was transferred from the Health and Safety Division of the Authority to act as her assistant. She also indicated later that problems arose because she often had to 'cope with very eminent, sometimes very difficult people'.[Footnote28](#) She also recognised that if she 'put a foot wrong' it would result in considerable problems for the UKAEA. Nevertheless, by 1968 drafts of *I&D* were beginning to take shape. The aim was to chart the history of the British nuclear weapons project from the decision to develop the bomb in secret, through the research, development, engineering and industrial phases, to the first nuclear test on 3 October 1952 at Monte Bello Islands, off the coast of Australia. The first volume was concerned with the 'Policy Making' aspects, focusing on 'Why' key decisions were made, and the second volume, focused on 'Policy Execution', dealing with 'How' the decisions were implemented. The drafts were submitted to the UKAEA, the Foreign Office and the MOD for vetting, which was more vigorous than *Britain and Atomic Energy*. The two volumes were subsequently published in November 1974 and were received with 'great fanfare'.[Footnote29](#)

In her preface Gowing, once again, insisted that she (and Arnold) had been given 'free access' to the documents (which as Departmental archivists they knew very well) and that they had stuck to 'professional historical standards'.[Footnote30](#) She also pointed out that the study had been overseen by the eminent historian, and Vice Chancellor of Oxford University, Sir Alan Bullock, who acted as honorary consultant to the UKAEA. She did, however, accept that because of 'space and time' parts of the scientific work had been omitted and that no attempt had been made to write about atomic intelligence matters. As a result of the comments from various interested government departments she also indicated that for 'compelling' reasons' she had omitted some technical details and made 'an extremely small number of other alterations'.[Footnote31](#)

The question arises, therefore, whether, the *highest* professional standards were in fact maintained given the omissions and changes that had been introduced. Unfortunately Gowing and Arnold do not indicate the subjects that had been omitted or the kinds of alterations made, apart from atomic intelligence. The reader has to take these changes on trust. In his otherwise very complimentary obituary of Margaret Gowing, written for the British Academy, Roy MacLeod argues that there were 'significant omissions in *I&D*. In his words: 'No attention was given to the wider context of the Cold War, nor to the highly sensitive area of nuclear intelligence, where discussion of the Fuchs incident or the Cambridge spies was still highly topical and secret'.[Footnote32](#) *I&D* does contain some discussion of the Fuchs case but, as Michael S. Goodman has shown, the true impact on Anglo-American nuclear and intelligence relations was far from complete in Gowing's and Arnold's official histories (Goodman [Citation2003](#)). The atomic intelligence relationship between the UK and US, in particular, during this period, as well as in later

periods, was of major importance in understanding the British nuclear story and the failure of *I&D* to deal with the subject of nuclear intelligence adequately is a significant omission. In the same way, it has been argued that a full understanding of World War Two was incomplete until the multi-volume official histories of intelligence were published between 1979 and 1993. As Richard Aldrich has argued, 'To understand properly the inner thoughts and purposes of those at the highest level, it is essential to inquire into the role of intelligence'. (Aldrich [Citation2004](#))

Another surprising omission is the failure to discuss the 1952 Global Strategy Paper (GSP) in any detail. During the period from April to June 1952 the British Chiefs of Staff were instructed by Prime Minister Churchill, to discuss the impact of nuclear weapons on British strategy. The report they produced in June 1952 (prior to the first British nuclear test in October) has been described by academic nuclear historians as 'one of the most significant' UK defence documents of the post-war period and as 'an important innovation in military thought'. It has also been described as 'a classic among military documents'. Churchill himself described it as 'a state paper of the greatest importance'.[Footnote33](#) Over the years academic nuclear historians have debated how significant it was and what impact, if any, it had on the United States 'New Look' defence policy and NATO strategy. These are important questions and, although Gowing and Arnold touch on the subject, their treatment of the 1952 Global Strategy Paper and the development of UK nuclear strategy is very limited, weakening the story of British nuclear weapons during the period covered. This is compounded by their failure to consider the early development of post-war UK nuclear strategy in general (Johnson [Citation1988](#)). This suggests that 'omission' needs to be an important part of the external scrutiny of UK official nuclear history.

That said, there is no denying that *I&D* was a major achievement which had a profound effect on the study of nuclear history in the UK. The two volumes were a 'resounding success' being described as 'a clear-eyed, monumental work', a 'groundbreaking official history', and 'foundational work'. Based on the experience of working with Hancock and sponsored by the UK Atomic Energy Authority, Gowing's and Arnold's two volumes became a model to be emulated as the new programme of peacetime histories took shape. They also had a major impact on academic nuclear historians, and in many ways established a new serious academic area of nuclear history in Britain. With access to highly secret documents from a range of departments concerned with the development of atomic weapons and atomic energy, (and the ability to conduct interviews with key scientists and officials), as the official historians, they were able to publish an account of British atomic energy developments between 1945 and 1952, which academic nuclear historians could not have written. Subsequent high quality academic nuclear histories would not have been possible without these volumes.

According to Roy MacLeod there is no doubt that Gowing 'enjoyed the prestige of working with the Cabinet Office' and the privileges and access that went with it.[Footnote34](#) If officials, however, expected *I&D* to be uncritical of UK policy they were to be mistaken. The volumes highlighted the secrecy in which the decision to develop nuclear weapons was made, without any real scrutiny in Parliament or within the Cabinet itself. This secrecy has been a feature of British nuclear policy and has been a feature of the nuclear policies of other nuclear states, as writers like Alex Wallerstein have shown. (Wallerstein [Citation2021](#), [Citation2025](#))[Footnote35](#) Gowing was clearly concerned about this secrecy, the question of public interest, and the importance of democratic accountability. Following Butterfield's emphasis on the complexity of the past, she was critical of the messy nature of the decision-making process. Kenneth Younger in a review of *I&D* argued that British policy on the bomb had been 'executed in ways that now seem profoundly muddled, even chaotic'. (Younger [Citation1975](#)) According to MacLeod the 'overriding theme in Volume 1 was that critical decisions had been taken without adequate consultation; that considerations of British self-interest had been sacrificed to the goal of closer collaboration with the United States; and that this goal was not attained because it was unattainable'.[Footnote36](#)

Implicit in the story are the author's reservations about American cooperation, especially the way Britain was let down by the McMahon Act of 1946. Despite wartime agreements that cooperation would continue in the post-war period, 'Britain had been left to find its own very expensive way forward in nuclear research and development', by the 1946 Act.[Footnote37](#) How these critical interpretations were viewed by government officials in the run up to publication when continued cooperation with the United States was a key theme of UK foreign and defence policy, and whether they tried to get modifications of the text (as they did with *Britain and Atomic Energy*) remains unknown. MacLeod argues, however, that 'Gowing's message 'was not warmly received by all in government'. Her revelations that the Americans 'led us up the garden path time after time' was not what the Foreign Office wanted to hear or read.[Footnote38](#) Nevertheless, the criticisms of government policy, does demonstrate that Gowing and Arnold were prepared to take an independent stance on issues they felt strongly about.

A more limited, specialized era of UK nuclear history

Following the publication of *I&D* in November 1974 it was envisaged that a new volume would be embarked upon, tentatively entitled *Independence to Interdependence or Interdependence Regained*, covering the period from 1952 to 1959 or perhaps 1963.[Footnote39](#) In practice, however, due to the overwhelming amount of material involved, as well as domestic and professional distractions, Gowing was never able to complete her third volume.

Lorna Arnold was increasingly left to her own devices. (L. Arnold [Citation2012](#))[Footnote40](#) Her solution to the scale of the task was to write a series of very specific official studies dealing with the nuclear test programme in Australia, the Windscale fire in 1957, and the UK development of thermonuclear weapons. Brian Cathcart has argued that Arnold brought to these projects 'the highest possible standards of official history writing' (Cathcart, [Citation2014](#)). Her earlier experience working in the civil service, especially in the UKAEA health and safety department, had given her 'a profound respect for the best in British public service', and her work with Gowing meant her approach was significantly influenced by Sir Keith Hancock's commitment to accessible official history, with a critical edge. She was, however, like Gowing, an 'insider'.

Her three main studies, nevertheless, dealt with highly controversial subjects. A *Very Special Relationship* published in 1986 focused on the nuclear tests carried out in Australia between 1952 and 1963.[Footnote41](#) In this study she provided detailed information in a lucid way of a series of tests, which was not previously available to academic nuclear historians. These included the 'Hurricane', 'Totem', 'Mosaic', 'Buffalo', 'Antler', 'Vixen' and 'Grapple' tests, which developed atomic and subsequently thermonuclear weapons. She also dealt with a number of highly contentious issues, including the contamination of the test sites, the effects of the tests on the local aboriginal peoples, and the emotionally charged issue of the nuclear veterans and the compensation issue. On these issues (and in an updated version entitled *Britain, Australia and the Bomb: The Nuclear Tests and their Aftermath*, with Mark Smith, in 2006) it has been argued that Arnold adopted an 'even-handed approach' and presented 'the evidence allowing others to draw their own conclusions'. (Cathcart [Citation2014](#)) There is also a critical edge to the study. She is scathing about the attitude of government officials at the time: 'Whitehall ... was mean at times, showed little awareness of Australian public opinion, and was often insensitive to Australian feelings'. (Carey [Citation1988](#)) Despite this, the question of whether all of the information retained by the government on the tests was made available to Arnold, or subsequently to the nuclear veterans themselves, has remained a highly controversial issue down to the present day, especially in terms of what many veterans claim to be suppressed medical records. (T. G. Kendall and Little [Citation2022](#); Michel, [Citation2003/9](#))[Footnote42](#) This is an issue which has had a very public dimension with the campaign by *The Mirror* to win compensation for the nuclear veterans and to highlight the different ways in which those veterans involved in nuclear testing programmes have been dealt with in other countries with nuclear weapons.[Footnote43](#)

Arnold's book on *Windscale 1957: Anatomy of a Nuclear Accident*, published in [Citation1992](#), also dealt with a highly controversial subject.[Footnote44](#) The Windscale fire which broke out on 10 October 1957 and burned for three days was one of the worst nuclear accidents in the world, releasing the radioactive

isotopes of iodine-131, caesium-137, xenon-133 and polonium-210 into the atmosphere (Garland and Wakeford [Citation2006](#)). The Macmillan government at the time tried to limit the amount of information available to the public for 'reasons of national security' and the official Report on the fire by the Chairman of the UKAEA, William Penney, was not made available at the National Archives until January 1988.[Footnote45](#) Significantly, however, Arnold's account is highly critical of the official government verdict on the responsibility for the fire. In a White Paper following the incident the blame was placed largely on the staff at Windscale. Arnold, however, contradicts this view arguing that the fire was 'an accident waiting to happen'. In her view the staff acted with 'outstanding courage, resourcefulness and devotion to duty' and she was angry that they had been 'publicly blamed, at the highest level, as contributing materially to the fire'. No doubt this conclusion was very much what some members of the UKAEA wanted to hear but it is likely to have been less well received by other departments in government. This would seem to reflect the accuracy of Brian Cathcart's view that in her writing she always 'tried to place a clear and accurate story before the public rather than serve the interests of the nuclear establishment'. (Cathcart [Citation2014](#))[Footnote46](#)

Perhaps the most remarkable of Arnold's official nuclear histories, and the one with the greatest impact on UK academic nuclear history, is her study of *Britain and the H-Bomb*, published in 2001 when she was 85 and the Cold War had come to an end. She was supported in her research for the book by Katherine Pyne, who was the technical historian at Aldermaston. The book charts the decision to develop thermonuclear weapons in 1954, through to the 'Grapple' tests in 1957/8, and the impact on Anglo-American nuclear relations which re-established far-reaching, and quite extraordinary, nuclear cooperation between the two countries.[Footnote47](#) The focus is on answering a series of key questions such as: Who was the father of the British H-Bomb? Was the decision to acquire a thermonuclear capability a 'rational' choice? What was the economic burden of the country's research and development programme? And whether Britain's H-Bomb efforts were justified for international security reasons, despite the threat to public health posed by atmospheric testing? The book, like her other studies, never loses track of the people among the policies and events she deals with.[Footnote48](#)

The detailed classified information about the weapons tested and the scientific and engineering hurdles faced in developing a British thermonuclear capability were largely unknown to academic historians who had studied the development of the UK nuclear deterrent. With the Cold War over the government adopted a more relaxed approach to matters of intelligence and nuclear weapons. In 1992/3 the Major government introduced the 'Waldegrave initiative' which was aimed at increasing transparency by reviewing and releasing thousands of previously restricted government documents, particularly in the fields of intelligence, nuclear history, and international relations. The 1993 White paper *Open Government* was designed to end

'absurd' secrecy' in order to address the criticisms of excessive secrecy in the 1980s. The initiative involved opening up significant MI5 files and other security records. This was followed by the Freedom of Information Act in 2000. In such an environment Arnold was able to publish a range of information about the development of Britain's thermonuclear weapons which had largely remained secret since the late 1950s.

The decision by the government to allow such a wide range of nuclear information to be published came at a time when the Blair administration was attempting to establish a close relationship with the Bush government by highlighting the remarkably close nuclear partnership, which had been developed as a result of Britain's nuclear expertise and the Mutual Defence Agreement (MDA) of 1958 which Blair wished to maintain and develop further. This was to come to fruition with the 'Exchange of Letters' between Blair and Bush in 2006. The nuclear relationship was at the heart of the 'special relationship' which was also reflected at the time in the close ties over operations in Afghanistan and Iraq. Arnold's book therefore may have highlighted, in the eyes of the Cabinet Office, the especially close and important relationship between the two countries.

What was also revealing was Arnold's argument about the limitations of official nuclear history. In the preface to *Britain and the H-Bomb* she points out that Prime Minister, Winston Churchill, had ordered that officials should 'avoid writing anything down unless it was absolutely necessary'. Significantly, she also reveals that: 'Many useful papers have undoubtedly been destroyed *deliberately* or inadvertently. In a radical but well-intentioned reorganization of Aldermaston's records 40 years ago, files were broken up and unsatisfactorily reassembled in some 6,500 synthetic new files which lack archival integrity, and in the process Penney's and Cook's directorate files were demolished. These are gaps in our scientific history that cannot be filled'.[Footnote49](#) This meant, according to one senior scientist at Aldermaston that, for anyone trying to tell Britain's nuclear story, 'it would be difficult to disentangle, and impossible for anyone working' solely from the documents'.[Footnote50](#) The problem also was that many of those involved were no longer alive. Arnold believed that the task was nevertheless worth it, to use what was available from classified sources to assist academic historians (with whom she worked quite closely) and inform the general public. (Baylis [Citation1994](#))[Footnote51](#) It was, however, a shame that she was not able to identify her sources from the classified archives which could be followed up and checked by academic nuclear historians.[Footnote52](#)

The question of 'institutionalization' is an interesting one. Both Gowing and Arnold spent a large part of their careers as government officials, working closely with officials from a wide range of government departments. It might be assumed, therefore, that they would have adopted what might be described as an 'official mindset', and that this would be reflected in their work as official historians. In fact, in general, this does not seem to have been the case. They

both liked the privileges of being an official historian with wide ranging access to secret government documents, nuclear scientists, and key officials. However, reflecting the influence of Keith Hancock, they were both independent, strong-minded women who were prepared to be critical of government policy where they disagreed with it, and, to live up to high historical professional standards, as far as they could. In her memoirs Lorna Arnold argued that: 'In my books I tried to be accurate and objective, and to allow the reader to draw their own conclusions. Suppressing my personal opinions was not without some risk: some of my friends and family imagined that my association and even friendships with those who produced nuclear weapons meant that I fully endorsed the development of those weapons'. She was also aware that as an official historian she was open to the suspicion of being 'a company spokeswoman'. In fact, rather surprisingly, she revealed, '*I am very much opposed to nuclear weapons, as well as to civil nuclear power*'.[Footnote53](#) This clearly is not the position of someone who had been 'institutionalized' into the nuclear establishment!

A new era of official nuclear history

Having completed her H-Bomb book, writing in 2000, Arnold argued that official nuclear history in Britain was likely to come to an end in the following year. The UKAEA, which had supported the project for the past 35 years could not support another new project. Official nuclear history was 'dead and beyond hope of resurrection', at least for the foreseeable future.[Footnote54](#) She made a plea, however, that there was a strong case for it continuing in some form. Privileged access to closed, and often highly classified records, which were not available to non-official historians added, she argued, 'extra dimensions and a deeper understanding' of the subject, which was of profound importance. This was particularly true in the nuclear field with its 'exceptionally high percentage of classified material'. (Arnold [Citation2000](#)).

In her memoirs, *My Short Century*, published in 2012, she gave a warning to her successor(s), if one was appointed: 'The records will be voluminous, but you will encounter frustrating gaps, some due to destruction. But much was never committed to paper at all, because of secrecy, or because so much work was done in conversations, calculations, or experiments'. Nevertheless, she argued there would be the opportunity for official nuclear historians to rub shoulders with, and learn from, a range of staff who had participated in the nuclear programme.[Footnote55](#)

There was no immediate response to Arnold's plea until 2008 when, in a new departure, Matthew Jones was appointed by the Prime Minister as the Cabinet Office official historian of the UK strategic nuclear deterrent and the Chevaline (Polaris Improvement) Programme.[Footnote56](#) This was a time when there was growing domestic and international interest in the process of de-nuclearization.

(Baylis and Eames [Citation2023b](#))[Footnote57](#) From the government's perspective, however, there was still a strong case for maintaining a minimum nuclear deterrent force. In December 2006 the government had announced its decision to replace the submarines carrying the Trident D5 missiles sparking off a major debate about the future of Britain's nuclear deterrent, and this seems to have contributed to the decision to commission a new major study of UK nuclear history. Faced with a recession, a major debate was underway about the decision to up-grade the Trident force given the high costs involved (estimated to be between £15 to £40 billion), especially in the new post-Cold War era. Given the government's determination to maintain a nuclear deterrent, a history that told the cautionary story of Chevaline with its search for greater independence, cost overruns and delays, appeared to reinforce the case for up-grading the Trident force and maintaining a close relationship with the United States.

Writing in the new more transparent environment Jones published his two volume official history in 2017. He stated that his aim was

to provide a broad study of Whitehall policy-making and attitudes toward the creation and development of a UK strategic nuclear deterrent capability, and against this essential background to explore how its effectiveness was viewed, along with steps that were seen as necessary to assure its continuing credibility.[Footnote58](#)

The main focus of the two volumes was on the background to, and development of, Chevaline, a redesigned front end of the Polaris A-3 missile (based in part on the US Antelope system) designed to overcome the Soviet Anti-Ballistic Missile (ABM) system, and still provide Britain with a degree of continuing independence in terms of its nuclear deterrent.[Footnote59](#)

With his 'free access' to archives from the Prime Minister's Office, the Cabinet Office, the MOD, the FCO, the Treasury, the AEA, the Ministry of Supply and the Ministry of Technology, as well as private papers, Jones provided a wide range of information, which was not available to non-official historians. It is 'a convoluted, multilayered and controversial story' in which he highlights the debates and disagreements that took place in both Conservative and Labour Governments, among officials about the nature of 'independence' and what it takes to deter. Particularly useful is the information he provides about the bureaucratic framework of policy-making and the wide range of committees and groups involved. These included, among others: the Joint Inter-Services Group for the Study of All-out War (JIGSAW); the British Nuclear Deterrent Study Group (BNDSG); the Joint Re-entry System Working Group (JRSWG); and the Joint Steering Task Group (JSTG)[Footnote60](#). In many ways the volumes reflect Butterfield's plea for granular, 'technical history'. The access to classified documents, Jones argues, 'allows us to better study the complex relationship between policy, strategy, science, and technology, and to understand more fully the reasons, choices, problems, and constraints involved'.[Footnote61](#) This

is particularly important in understanding the changing nature of the Anglo-American nuclear relationship over the period covered, including the 'drift' in the nuclear relationship between 1965 and 1969.

There is also a critical edge to Jones's official history which reflects the approach recommended by Keith Hancock and followed by Margaret Gowing and Lorna Arnold. Jones highlights the secret nature of the Polaris Improvement Programme and the Chevaline project and its concealment from Parliament. He also deals with the very significant cost overruns, project mismanagement deficiencies, technical problems and the 'dithering' of Conservative and Labour governments over the programme. Although many of these difficulties had been in the public domain for some time, Jones's two volumes provide an in-depth analysis, not only of the technical complexities of the project, but also the range of weaknesses from which the project suffered and the private debates which took place in secret among government officials over its strategic value.[Footnote62](#)

Besides the benefits of the detailed knowledge provided by the two volumes, however, there are some questions which arise from his official histories. Gowing's and Arnold's *I&D* volumes covered a period of seven years (1945–1952) and in their follow up research, focusing on the period 1952 to 1959, they found that the volume of material was so great that it would be impossible to undertake the project. (This is reflected in Arnold's warning to her successor in her 2000 article.) Jones's two volumes cover a period of 25 years (from 1945 to 1970). It remains unclear why one project, covering the period from 1952 to 1959, initiated by the two official historians became impossible, while another covering a much longer period (including the period covered by Gowing and Arnold) was undertaken 'successfully'.[Footnote63](#)

One explanation, it might be argued, is that, like all historians, Jones adopts a selective approach to his material which was justifiable given the volume of the archives he was dealing with. In doing so, however, there are some significant omissions, which for some 'outside' nuclear historians seem surprising. An interesting issue is the question of Anglo-French diplomacy during the period covered. There is some discussion of Anglo-French nuclear cooperation but there is no coverage of the question of whether Britain gave some help to the French thermonuclear programme in early 1967. According to Pierre Billaud, a senior French scientist involved in the programme, and Venance Journé, William Cook, a key figure in the development of the British H-Bomb, approached the military attaché at the French embassy in London, Andre Thoulouze, and passed on some information 'of a purely technical nature' which helped to put the French programme back on track after some unsuccessful tests. (Billaud and Journé [Citation2008](#))[Footnote64](#) This is quite a remarkable and controversial claim which, even if erroneous, deserves some discussion in the official history. It's an issue which has been taken up in the academic nuclear history literature (Butler [Citation1996](#); Stoddart [Citation2007](#)).

Was it left out because of the sensitive nature of the claim in the context of UK relations with France or because the documents relating to the issue were not available? We are not told, and unlike Arnold's work there is no explanation of the limitations of the documentary record. Despite the more liberal approach initiated by the Waldegrave Initiative the question of the reasons for 'omissions', such as this, continues to raise questions for 'outside' nuclear historians and demonstrates the importance of Butterfield's call for official histories to be subjected to 'unremitting scrutiny'.[Footnote65](#)

There is also the question of the academic literature available at the time of the publication of the two official history volumes. In his preface, Jones says that he is 'acutely aware' that 'many academic scholars of British nuclear history during the Cold War era have paved the way for others by their often careful and scrupulous examination of the open documentary record'.[Footnote66](#) This makes his two volume official nuclear history rather different to the previous works of Gowing and Arnold. Their studies covered virgin territory, which was almost completely unknown to academic historians and the general public. In contrast, the general story covered by Jones was generally already well known. According to a reviewer, Andrew Dorman, 'the significant time-lag between Gowing's and Arnold's histories and Jones's volumes has meant that the latter were released after many of the archives themselves were made public and increasing numbers of the participants themselves are no-longer with us providing the 'first insights into the archives as they had done in the past'. Dorman goes on to argue that while Jones acknowledges the existence and value of the academic literature on British nuclear policies covered by the two volumes 'he does not really engage with the existing literature or provide any insight into where the official history might provide an alternative or more nuanced understanding'. It is also surprising that some of the academic literature dealing with the Chevaline project, the main focus of the two volumes, is not mentioned in the references provided.[Footnote67](#)

Despite this kind of critical scrutiny, Jones does provide detailed references to a range of archives he has used. Gowing only provided her sources many years after *I&D* was published, and Arnold in her *H-Bomb* book, valuable as it is, relies largely on secondary sources, with a promise to provide more detailed sources at a later date.[Footnote68](#) The provision of detailed references to specific archives in the Jones volumes is an advance on previous official histories. The question of sources, nevertheless, remains somewhat problematical. Some of the archives referenced remain unavailable for reasons of secrecy and even some of those deposited in The National Archives in Kew are sometimes difficult or impossible to access because they are said to be out for 'use by government departments'.[Footnote69](#) There is also the significant problem that many documents were destroyed, as well as the fact that much was not written down. This, therefore, remains a significant difficulty for academic nuclear historians undertaking an 'unremitting scrutiny' of the work of the official historians. Butterfield is correct, therefore, that it remains impossible for academic historians, especially nuclear (and intelligence) historians, to check all

of the sources of the official nuclear historians. As Arnold has argued, even the documents themselves do not reveal all of the story. In her memoirs she stated: 'I understood how inadequate a picture such documents provide without looking at the working papers and talking to the people involved'.[Footnote70](#)

Conclusion

The debate about official history and academic history remains as lively today as it was in the late 1940s and 1950s when Butterfield wrote about the subject. (Trentmann and Parkinson [Citation2020](#))[Footnote71](#) It is a debate that creates strong emotions, particularly when it involves issues as dangerous, controversial and important as nuclear weapons. For some, like Butterfield, academic history must remain not only paramount, but uncontaminated by any association with government. Historians must be allowed to follow the truth wherever it might lead, without interference by officials whose interest, in 'controlling the past', as well as protecting state secrets, are quite different.

The official nuclear historians, Gowing, Arnold and Jones, like many other UK official historians in the past, claim that they have been given 'completely free access' to the documents and have faced only very minor requests from officials to make modifications to their texts. They also point to the independent scrutiny of well-respected senior historians who oversee their work. They claim that their studies represent an important and legitimate contribution to historical analysis. Martin Blumenson, a US official military historian, who asks the question 'Can Official History be Honest History?' argues that despite the need for secrecy, vetting, and some lost documents, there is no reason why official history cannot be 'honest history'. (Blumenson [Citation1962/3](#))[Footnote72](#)

Questions nevertheless remain for academic historians. How is it possible for non-official nuclear historians to tell if the officially appointed historians have in fact been given complete access to all the relevant documents, even if they claim to have had 'a free run of the archives'? (Hennessy [Citation2014](#)) How would the official historians themselves know if they had been deceived by officials? As it has been argued by one official historian: 'if deception has been successful, we simply don't know what has been concealed or destroyed'.[Footnote73](#) How is it possible for outside observers to know if documents are withheld on grounds of political sensitivities about the reputations of high-level decision-makers or the demands of allied nations? Also, how is it possible for official historians themselves to know whether destroyed documents, or information not written down on the instruction of high-level policymakers, might not be of critical importance in understanding the evolution of policy? When official historians engage in self-censorship on the grounds that they do not include information in their studies because they 'know' that it will not pass 'the scrutiny of the sensitivity reviewers', how can

their judgment be challenged? How can a rounded and meaningful understanding of nuclear history be achieved if relevant intelligence information is withheld? The answers to all these questions can only be taken on trust by the academic nuclear historian. In this sense the issues that arise from an analysis of UK official nuclear histories are similar to the issues that arise over other official histories, especially those relating to military operations and intelligence. In another sense, however, given the overwhelming power of nuclear weapons and the catastrophic consequences of their use, the questions of secrecy and the importance of scrutiny in a democratic context means that an analysis of the nuclear (as well as intelligence) histories brings an additional dimension to the historiography of official history.

Patrick Salmon, has argued in his very thoughtful analysis of the 'pros and cons' of official history in general, that while Butterfield's critique may often be based more on assertion than evidence, there have been some worrying examples of governmental interference in the writing of official history in the past.[Footnote74](#) He concedes, therefore, that Butterfield has a serious point to make. He accepts that Official Historians 'have crossed the line' and 'the ghost of Butterfield will always be there ... taking a pot shot with his rifle'.[Footnote75](#) Salmon's solution is an acceptance of the importance of continuing 'unremitting scrutiny' of official histories. He recognizes that official history isn't perfect but that it nevertheless provides an important 'foundational basis' for academic history which would not be possible without the kind of access to documents made available to official historians. Certainly, there is no denying that the works of Gowing, Arnold and Jones have helped to improve the academic study and popular knowledge of nuclear history in the UK, through their books and particularly through the close relationship that has, at times, been forged between official and non-official historians.[Footnote76](#) There is no doubt, as Arnold has argued, that: 'Privileged access is especially valuable for nuclear history because of the exceptionally high proportion of classified material in this field. Privileged access opens up a wealth of scientific records, and so changes the nature of the research material – as well as increasing its volume'. 'The official historian', she says, 'is then better able to study the complex relationship between policy, strategy, science, and technology, and to understand more fully the reasons, choices, and constraints involved. The hard realities behind high-level decisions can be seen more clearly'.[Footnote77](#)

That privileged access, however, comes with a price. As Sir Lawrence Freedman, the official historian of the Falklands War, (and one of Britain's leading nuclear strategists), has conceded, scholars enter into a 'Faustian Bargain' when they become official historians, getting 'amazing access to the archives and to people, but with conditions'[Footnote78](#) Those conditions involve not publishing some things that the government regards as secret. Freedman, says he felt a sense of great frustration '*of knowing something that I could not tell anybody*'.[Footnote79](#) Gill Bennett, with a long and distinguished record working

in the Cabinet Office and as the Chief Historian in the Foreign and Commonwealth Office, has highlighted the vital role of secrecy and the limited nature of many official histories: 'As official historians, we are ... keenly aware of the fact that there are secrets that must remain secret'. Government historians, she argues, have a duty to protect information that must not be revealed to the public, 'sometimes for ever'. (Bennet [Citation2025](#))

The critical question of secrecy and the availability of archives raises the question of whether there can be common ground between official nuclear historians and academic nuclear historians. There are those, like Jack Holl and Jeremy Black, who argue that there is such a cultural gap between the two that finding common ground is impossible (Black [Citation2006](#); Holl [Citation2008](#)). They are divided, Holl argues, by 'work culture, which is framed by distinctive identity, values, perspective and mission'.[Footnotes0](#) This view would seem to be largely supported by Butterfield's critique of official history and his argument in favour of 'history for its own sake'. Official histories, including the nuclear histories, in contrast, have a purpose other than simply providing authoritative history. They are designed to provide 'a fund of experience' for future government use and an aid to 'institutional memory'. They also have a purpose of reinforcing government policy (Pilling [Citation2009](#)). These differences of purpose create barriers, Black argues, which means that official historians and academic historians are not 'simply variants of a unified academic-based scholarly culture'. (Black [Citation2015](#))

The difficulty of establishing common ground between official and nonofficial nuclear historians is also made by Jonathan Hogg in his study of *British Nuclear Culture: Official and Unofficial Narratives in the Long 20th Century*. This sociological study argues that state power has been critical in the writing of official nuclear history. He sees UK official histories are part of a deliberately constructed narrative designed to reinforce the state's case for the need for nuclear weapons. Nuclear culture, he argues, has been part of a pervasive and persistent aspect of British life that is designed by the political elite to undermine anti-nuclear sentiments. According to this view, the official histories reflect the arrogance of policy-makers in their dealings with academic historians and the wider public. Privileged access allows state-sponsored historians to dominate the narrative about nuclear weapons and to close down alternative, critical views.

The question of whether there can be some common ground between official and non-official historians remains a matter of debate. Butterfield himself was not totally opposed to official history. An analysis, particularly of the work of Lorna Arnold, suggests that a more nuanced judgement is possible. Arnold's suggestion that privileged access to closed, and often highly classified records, not available to non-official historians, does provide an extra dimension and depth to the subject that is of value to academic nuclear historians. In her work she attempted with some success to highlight the important and valuable 'foundational' aspects of UK official nuclear history and its contribution to the

academic study of the United Kingdom's nuclear history.[Footnote81](#) Seen in these terms, official nuclear history is 'honest history', with significant limitations, but there are opportunities to bridge the gap between the two fields of nuclear history. Societal changes have brought greater transparency and the availability of a wider range of documents has allowed a much greater scrutiny than in the past. The 'secret state' (to use Peter Hennessy's term) is now *relatively* less secret (Hennessy [Citation2003](#)). This said, given the continuing differences in access, the inevitable requirements of secrecy, as well as the opportunity, as Wallerstein argues, for secrecy to be used as a tool of government (D'Agostino [Citation2021a](#)), together with the continuing 'missing dimension of nuclear intelligence', the unanswered questions about 'omissions', and the constraints imposed by the vetting process, it would be naive to believe that governments are no longer interested in 'controlling the nuclear past'. As such the historiography of UK nuclear history remains a highly contested field.

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John Baylis is Emeritus Professor at Swansea University. Before retirement he was Professor of International Politics and Dean of Social Sciences at Aberystwyth University, and Head of the Department of Politics and International Relations and Pro Vice-Chancellor at Swansea University. His books include *Sharing Nuclear Secrets: Trust, Mistrust and Ambiguity in Anglo-American Nuclear Relations*, with Anthony Eames, (Oxford University Press, 2023); *The British Nuclear Experience: The Role of Beliefs, Culture and Identity* with Kristan Stoddart (Oxford University Press, 2015); *The Globalization of World Politics: An Introduction to International Relations* ed. with Sir Steve Smith and Patricia Owens (10th Edition, Oxford University Press, 2026); *Strategy in the Contemporary World: An Introduction to Strategic Studies* ed. with James Wirtz, Jeannie Johnson and Danielle Cohen (8th Edition, Oxford University Press, 2026); and *Ambiguity and Deterrence: British Nuclear*

Strategy 1945-1964, (Oxford University Press, 1995). He has a long term interest in Official UK nuclear history.

Notes

1. The question of what is, and what is not, an 'official' nuclear history is a matter of some dispute. In his study *The Control of the Past: Herbert Butterfield and the Pitfalls of Official History*, (London, 2021) Patrick Salmon produces a list of UK Official Histories which includes only the works of Matthew Jones and does not include the books by Margaret Gowing or Lorna Arnold, sponsored by the UKAEA and not the Cabinet Office. Most academic nuclear historians, however, regard Gowing's and Arnold's books as 'official' histories. There are several other works which might be regarded as 'official' nuclear histories, these include: H.Wynn, *The RAF Strategic Nuclear Deterrent Forces: their origins, roles and deployment 1946–1969. A Documentary*, MOD, 1991) later published as *RAF Nuclear Deterrent Forces*, (London, 1994); J. Hendry, *Technological Decision Making in its Organizational Context: Nuclear Power Reactor Development in Britain*, (Cambridge, Research paper No. 4/91) and *Fusion Research in the UK 1945–1960*', (London, AHO1, 1993), and S. Keith, *The Fundamental Nucleus: A Study of the Impact of the British Atomic Energy Project on Basic research*', (London, AHO2, 1993).

2. L. Arnold, *A Very Special Relationship: British Atomic Weapons Trials in Australia*, (London, 1987), second edition with M. Smith, *Britain, Australia and the Bomb: Nuclear Tests and their Aftermath*, (Basingstoke, 2006); *Windscale 1957: Anatomy of a Nuclear Accident*, (Basingstoke, 1992); *Britain and the H-Bomb*, (Basingstoke, 2001).

3. M. Jones, *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume 1 - from the V-Bomber era to the arrival of Polaris, 1945–1964*, (London, 2017) and *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume II-the Labour Government and the Polaris Programme, 1964–1970*, (London, 2017). A third volume is currently being written.

4. There are some reviews of the various official histories and some academic oversight of the histories as they were written, but there is very little detailed external academic scrutiny of the histories. In the two-part series on UK official history in *Diplomacy and Statecraft*, 36:3/4, 2025, there is no coverage of the nuclear histories.

5. H. Butterfield, 'Official History: Its Pitfalls and Criteria', *Studies: An Irish Quarterly Review*, xxxviii, June 1949, reproduced in *History and Human Relations*, (London, 1951); B.H. Liddell Hart, 'Responsibility and Judgment in Historical Writing', *Military Affairs*, Spring, 1959 and *Why Don't we Learn From History?* published by his son after his death, (London, 2012).

6. Salmon provides a very useful outline of the historical development of writing official history in Britain in his book *The Control of the Past*. Salmon is also one of the editors (with Richard Smith) of two special issues of *Diplomacy and Statecraft*, 36:3, 36:4 2025/6. Their Introduction sets out a critical framework for assessing various official history case studies, 551–557.

7. Butterfield's books included: *The Whig Interpretation of History*, (London, 1931); *Christianity and History*, (London, 1949); *George III, Lord North and the People 1779–1780* (London, 1949); *History and Human Relations*, (London, 1951); *The Origins of Modern Science*, (London, 1951); and *George III and the Historians*, (London, 1957).

8. Butterfield, 'Official History'.

9. 'Butterfield to Taylor', 2 August 1949, quoted in Salmon, *The Control of the Past*, 4.

10. Butterfield, 'Official History'.

11. In the late 1940s various volumes of interwar and wartime documents were published, including E.L. Woodward and R. Butler, *Documents on British Foreign Policy 1919–1939* (London, 1946) and the multi-volume series *Documents on German Foreign Policy 1918–1945* published from 1949 onwards (London, 1949). Butterfield argued that the selection of documents risked creating a distorted historical narrative that favoured government perspectives. He was critical of both narrative and documentary official histories for much the same reasons.

12. Butterfield, 'Official History'.

13. Butterfield's correspondence with various Official Historians is dealt with in Salmon, *The Control of the Past*.

14. Desmond Williams was Professor of Modern History at University College Dublin from 1949 to 1983. He worked for the Foreign Office editing the papers of the German Foreign Ministry for the period 1919–1945. This experience raised his concerns of attempts by the British government to control the selection of documents to publish. He became a research student at Peterhouse, Cambridge where he established a very close relationship with Herbert Butterfield, with whom he shared similar ideas about the pitfalls of official history.

15. Butterfield, 'Official History'.

16. Liddell Hart, 'Responsibility and Judgment in Historical Writing'.

17. *Ibid.*

18. Butterfield, 'Official History'. Butterfield was rather sensitive about accusing various official historians that he knew of being 'dishonest'. He therefore suggested that other official historians in the future might not be so honest.

19. Elton argues that Butterfield focused largely on 'letters and dispatches'. 733.

20. Salmon, *The Control of the Past*, 46.

21. *Ibid.* The work was first planned in the late 1950s after a major defence agreement with the US, the 1958 Mutual Defence Agreement. The government was concerned to highlight Britain's contribution to the Manhattan Project during the Second World War. In a number of conversations between the author and Gowing and Arnold it was clear that they both felt the need to put on the record the British contribution to the development of nuclear weapons because of a tendency in the US to claim that the nuclear story was essentially an American story.

22. *Ibid.*

23. 'References to Official Papers' were released in July 1980 and April 1983 by the Authority Historian's Office of the UKAEA. Even then, in the author's experience, some documents were not always available to academic nuclear historians. They were said to be 'retained' for use in other departments.

24. The Profumo Scandal between 1961 and 1963 involved lies being told by Macmillan's Secretary of State for War in a statement to the House of Commons, leading to his resignation. The affair severely damaged the Macmillan government and the reputation of the Prime Minister himself.

25. This story was related by the official historian Matthew Jones in his talk 'What shall we tell Mrs Gowing', at a seminar entitled 'Margaret Gowing and British Nuclear History: Reflections on her life, achievements, and legacy', LSE IDEAS-NATO-LSE Department of International History Conference, 5 December 2016. As an official historian Jones had access to the documents on this matter.

26. *Ibid.*

27. Matthew Jones 'What shall we tell Mrs Gowing?'.

28. *Ibid.* Quoted from a letter Gowing sent to J.Charles, 21 July 1964 from the Gowing Papers. History of Science Museum, Oxford, (HSM).

29. Arnold, 'Letter from Oxford: The History of Nuclear History in Britain,' *Minerva*, 38(2), June 2000.

30. What exactly she meant by that was not spelled out.

31. Gowing, *Independence and Deterrence*, Vol. 1, ix-xi.

32. MacLeod, 'Margaret Mary Gowing', 302.

33. For the debate about the 1952 Global Strategy Paper see E.J.Grove, *Vanguard to Trident British Naval Policy Since World War Two*, (London, 1987); J. Slessor, *The Central Blue: Recollections and Reflections*, (London, 1956); A. Pierre, *Nuclear Politics: The British Experience with an*

Independent Strategic Force 1939–1970; (Oxford, 1972); R.N Rosecrance, *Defense of the Realm: British Strategy in the Nuclear Epoch* (New York, 1968); I. Clark and N.J. Wheeler, *The British Origins of Nuclear Strategy 1945–1955*, (Oxford, 1989); and J. Baylis and A. Macmillan, 'The Global Strategy Paper of 1952', *The Journal of Strategic Studies*, 16, (2), 1993. Different versions of the 1952 Paper were made available to the author in the Cabinet office in the early 1990s. One version was for British eyes only and another version shared with the US.

34. MacLeod, 'Margaret Mary Gowing', 274.

35. Wallerstein's argument suggests that the history US nuclear weapons 'is inseparable from secrecy, classification and state control of knowledge'. (I am grateful to an anonymous reviewer for pointing this out to me). A comparative study of nuclear histories is another significant gap in the literature on the subject.

36. MacLeod, 'Margaret Mary Gowing', 302.

37. *Ibid*, 302–3.

38. *Ibid.*, 303.

39. Arnold, 'Letter from Oxford'.

40. Arnold had her own domestic challenges at this time. She was a single parent with two children, in what she describes as 'a man's world'. Arnold also left the diplomatic service in 1949 because she felt (or was made to feel) that men returning from the war had more right to diplomatic positions than she did. As she says in her memoirs: 'The diplomatic service was so exclusively masculine' at the time. (*My Short Century*, 109). Margaret Gowing was also very conscious of working in a field dominated by male scientists and policy makers. See MacLeod, 'Margaret Mary Gowing'.

41. Arnold, *A Very Special Relationship*.

42. The question of compensation for nuclear veterans continued to be controversial in 2026. The British Nuclear Test Veterans Association argue that the full information about medical tests on servicemen who were present at the nuclear tests has been withheld from them. On taking office in July 2026, Prime Minister, Andy Burnham, promised the veterans that a new inquiry would look into their treatment during the nuclear testing programme.

43. See 'The Damned', <https://damned.mirror.co.uk>. There is also the question of the impact of the testing programme on indigenous peoples which has been the source of considerable controversy.

44. The publication of *Windscale 1957* in 1992 took place at the end of the Cold War, which led to questioning of the contemporary utility of nuclear weapons, and also a continuing debate about the safety of nuclear programmes in the UK

and elsewhere, which was a result of the Three Mile Island nuclear accident in March 1979 and the Chernobyl Disaster in April 1986.

45. The Report of the Committee of Inquiry (The Penney Report) is reproduced in The National Archives (TNA), File AB 86/25, January 1988.

46. See also *The Times* Obituary, 31 March 2014.

47. B.Cathcart, 'The Obituary of Lorna Arnold', *The Guardian*, March 27, 2014. It has been rumoured in more recent years that government officials felt that perhaps too much had been revealed in the book because of the growing concerns about the problems of nuclear proliferation. (Private correspondence between the author and a well-respected source, who wished to remain anonymous, October 2025). This view seems to be supported by Richard Aldrich who has argued that in the post-Cold War period, despite periods of a more liberal approach to secret matters, at times, 'the authorities attempted to close material that had been open to scholars for two decades ... ' because of changing perspectives and geopolitical events, Aldrich, 'Policing the Past', 934.

48. Arnold, *Britain the H-Bomb*, xii.

49. *Ibid.* xii-xiii. Penney and Cook were the two key scientists involved in the development of the UK's atomic and thermonuclear weapons.

50. *Ibid.*, xiii.

51. She worked quite closely with a number of academic historians.

52. Arnold points out in the 'Notes and References' section of *Britain and the H-Bomb* that most of the files she consulted were still in the AWE archives and were closed. She expressed her hope that a booklet containing references to these files might be produced at some point in the future. To the author's knowledge this was never done. Arnold, *Britain and the H-Bomb*, 247.

53. Arnold, *My Short Century*, 194.

54. Arnold, 'Letter from Oxford', 213.

55. Arnold, *My Short Century*, 169.

56. The Pilling Report on the future of official histories was produced in 2008–9 and recommended a continuation of government support for official history – with only limited results.

57. An article appeared in *The Wall Street Journal* in January 2007 written by four US elder statesmen, George Shultz, William Perry, Henry Kissinger and Sam Nunn arguing for progress towards de-nuclearization. A similar article appeared in *The Times* in June 2008 written by four senior UK politicians, Malcolm Rifkind, David Owen, George Robertson and Douglas Hurd.

58. Jones, *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume 1*, xii-xiii.

59. Jones is currently working on his third and concluding volume covering the period from 1970 to 1982.

60. These reflect the wide range of different groups involved in the nuclear decision making process in the UK.

61. Jones, *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume 1*, xiv.

62. It is anticipated that Jones will develop many of these points further in his third volume.

63. It is not altogether clear why Volume 1 goes back over the 1945–52 period covered in I&D.

64. Billaud argues that, at a time when the French nuclear testing programme was facing difficulties, the information from Cook reinforced support for a design of a thermonuclear device produced by Michel Carayol which had not been supported previously. It was the testing of this device which led to the successful development of the French H-Bomb (Operation 'Canopus') in August 1968.

65. Other omissions include important questions of the command and control of nuclear weapons, as well as the impact of the nuclear testing programme, and the limited approach to issues of nuclear intelligence. Unlike Gowing and Arnold, Jones is a professional academic historian. It is a pity that he does not address the question of whether or not tensions existed between officials and himself, given his role as both an official and an academic historian. Other official historians who have also been official historians have done this. See L. Freedman, 'Taking Stock of Official History, Past, Present and Future', *Diplomacy and Statecraft*, 36:3, 2025, 558–9.

66. Jones, *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume 1*, xiv. This literature included: K. Stoddart, *Losing an Empire and Finding a Role: Britain, the U.S.A., NATO and Nuclear Weapons, 1964–1970* (Basingstoke, Macmillan, 2012); K. Stoddart, *The Sword and the Shield: Britain and America, NATO, and Nuclear Weapons, 1970–1976* (Basingstoke, Macmillan, 2014); K. Stoddart, *Facing down the Soviet Union: Britain, the U.S.A., NATO and Nuclear Weapons, 1976–1983* (Basingstoke, 2014); J. Baylis, *Ambiguity and Deterrence: British Nuclear Strategy, 1945–1964* (Oxford, 1995); J. Baylis and K. Stoddart, *The British Nuclear Experience: The Role of Beliefs, Culture and Identity*, (Oxford, 2015); R. Moore, *Nuclear Illusion, Nuclear Reality: Britain, the United States and Nuclear Weapons, 1958–1964* (Basingstoke, 2010); J. Simpson, *The Independent Nuclear State: The United States, Britain, and the Military Atom* (Basingstoke, 1986); I. Clark, *Nuclear Diplomacy and the Special Relationship: Britain's Deterrent and America, 1957–1962* (Oxford, 1994); I. Clark and N. Wheeler, *The*

British Origins of Nuclear Strategy, 1945–1955 (Oxford, 1989); and J.R.Walker *Britain and Disarmament; Nuclear, Biological and Chemical Weapons Arms Control and Programmes 1956–1975*, (Farnham, 2012).

67. A. Dorman, Review of *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume 1 - from the V-Bomber era to the arrival of Polaris, 1945–1964*, and *The Official History of the UK Strategic Nuclear Deterrent: Volume II- the Labour Government and the Polaris Programme, 1964–1970*, *International Affairs*, 95, (5,), 2019. Other criticisms might be that Jones does not deal with the broader domestic debates about nuclear weapons, including the ethical debates, and that, like his predecessors, he does not deal adequately with crucial nuclear intelligence matters. It would have been interesting to know if any vetting issues arose during the publication process, whether any changes in the text were required, and the nature of any academic oversight.

68. See Note 23 and 52.

69. The present author has suffered from this difficulty.

70. Arnold, *My Short Century*, 184.

71. Online seminars at the Institute of Historical Research (IHR), ‘Taking Stock of Official History, past present and future’, February 2025, <https://www.history.ac.uk>. The IHR seminar series also included a discussion of international perspectives on official history.

72. It does seem that there is a potential for a conflict of interest associated with official history due to sources of funding, employment issues, and the various constraints under which official historians often operate.

73. Salmon, *The Control of the Past*. 66.

74. These include difficulties in revealing the Windsor Papers in the 1940s and 50s; concerns about the official history of strategic bombing in the Second World War; and the delay in publishing Michael Howard’s *Intelligence History* during the Thatcher era. *Ibid.*, 18, 46–7, 51–2.

75. *Ibid*, 68.

76. The Nuclear History Programme (NHP) funded by the Ford Foundation, the Volkswagen-Stiftung, John D. and Catherine T. MacArthur Foundation, and the German Marshall Foundation, brought scientists, engineers, officials and academics from a number of different countries together for conferences in the 1980s and 1990s which provided an excellent basis for cooperation between official and unofficial historians, as well as those directly involved in nuclear weapons programmes. Gowing and Arnold were important members of this Programme. More recently the Charterhouse British History seminars organized by Richard Moore every two years also provides a useful basis for meetings between officials and academic historians.

77. Arnold, *My Short Century*, 169.

78. Freedman, 'Taking Stock of Official History'.

79. *Ibid.*, 562.

80. J.M.Joll, 'Cultures in Conflict', 30.

81. Arnold was an enthusiastic participant in the Nuclear History Programme and worked closely with academics in the field. See footnote 76.

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